Combat rule – Knocking a creature out · SRD 5.2.1

When a **melee** attack would reduce a creature to **0 HP**, the attacker may choose to **knock it out**: the creature drops to **1 HP** and becomes **Unconscious** instead of dying or falling dying.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Only after a **melee** attack.
2. The target drops to **1 HP**, **Unconscious**.
3. A **Short Rest** ends the condition.
4. **Healing** or **Medicine DC 10** wakes it earlier.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 replaces the 2014 “nonlethal damage”: the choice is made at the moment of the fatal blow.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn’t say whether a spell can knock out. Fix: only **melee** allows this choice, unless the DM says otherwise.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the target collapsing, stunned, rather than dead.

Step 1 – Announce:

Before the damage roll or after the hit, say "I knock it out."

Step 2 – Check:

The attack is **melee** and would bring the target to 0 HP.

Step 3 – Apply:

The target drops to **1 HP** and becomes **Unconscious**.

Step 4 – Duration:

It begins a **Short Rest**; the condition ends at the end of the rest.

Step 5 – Early wake-up:

Regaining HP or a successful **Wisdom (Medicine) DC 10** ends it.

Example: Bryn hits a bandit down to 0 HP. He chooses to knock him out: the bandit stays at 1 HP, unconscious, and will be questioned.

⚠ Common questions:

Can a spell knock out?

No, only a melee attack.

How many HP remain?

1 HP.

How long does it last?

A Short Rest.

How do I wake it?

Healing or Medicine DC 10.

Are there death saves?

No, the target is at 1 HP and stable.

Can I knock out a monster?

Yes, the DM decides.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Ranged weapons

Can I knock out with a bow?
Option: yes at point-blank range.

Massive damage

Does a huge blow still kill? **Option**: no if knocking out.

Bosses

Can a boss be knocked out? **Option**: yes, but it wakes quickly.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

1 HP

The target stays at 1 HP, not 0.

Unconscious condition

Ends at a Short Rest, healing or Medicine DC 10.

Death rules

See the HP, healing and death sheet.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

Notices: This work includes material from the System Reference Document 5.2.1 ("SRD 5.2.1") by Wizards of the Coast LLC, available at https://www.dndbeyond.com/srd. The SRD 5.2.1 is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License, available at https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/legalcode. Unofficial sheet, 5E compatible (2024 rules), neither approved nor sponsored by Wizards of the Coast. Rules come from SRD 5.2.1; where the SRD gives no answer, explanations rely on our own interpretation. The "Table rule" parts are the author's own creations. Borders, banner, texture, titles, layout, table rules and examples: © Jaja, all rights reserved. Sources: SRD 5.2.1 (official English version); rule clarifications cross-checked with answers found on the web and reworded; numeric examples are invented; last revised: November 2026. Fonts: TeX Gyre Pagella (GUST), DejaVu Sans, Noto Color Emoji (OFL).